Newsletter: April 2025

Overview

Hello river champions. Its been a little while since the last newsletter, and we wanted to provide updates on a few points:

- A university-led community workshop on the River Cole;
- Aimee, our student that has been on placement with us;
- Birmingham River Champions on Midlands Today;
- Your data on pollution across Birmingham's rivers;
- Upcoming events

Community workshop

University academics recently held a workshop with the Friends of Trittiford Park and Pool, Hall Green's Keepin' It Clean and Sarehole Environmental Action Team. Off the back of walking interviews with volunteers, we wanted to look into how communities engage with and value the Cole. Important features like the stepping stones and the sound of flowing water were identified, while concerns were raised on aspects like pollution and litter. A publicly available report will be released in the coming months.



Student Placement

Since January, Aimee Entwistle - a 3rd year undergraduate student at the University of Birmingham - has worked with groups in southwest Birmingham. She has supported monitoring activities and helped volunteers with their sampling and identification skills. Along with our committed volunteers, Aimee has detected threats in the Upper Rea, with species-poor samples uncovered at Balaam's Wood and Lifford Reservoir. She did however sample a diverse community at Senneleys Park, which even contained a stonefly – this is very encouraging given how hyper-sensitive these little critters are to pollution. This would have been our first stonefly in the project if weren't for the Friends of Sutton Park uncovering their first just two-weeks before!



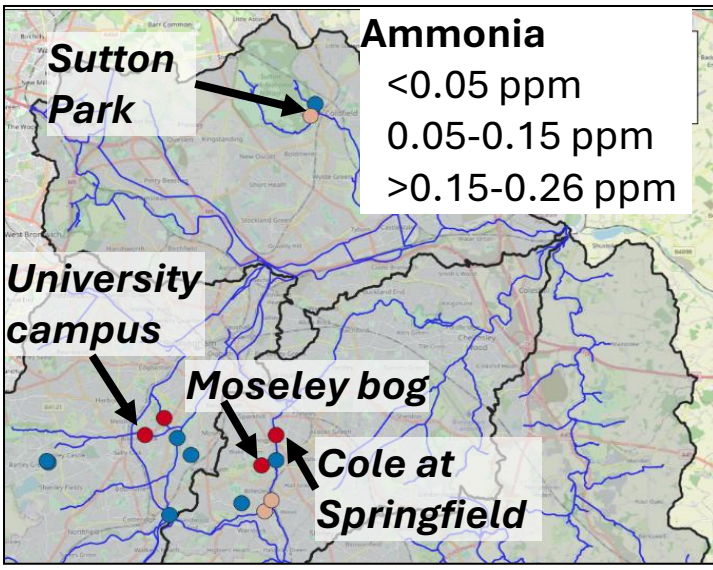
We hope that Aimee's time has helped instil more confidence for these volunteers on monitoring river health. We would like to thank the groups who hosted and welcomed Aimee, and we wish her the best of luck with the remainder of her studies.

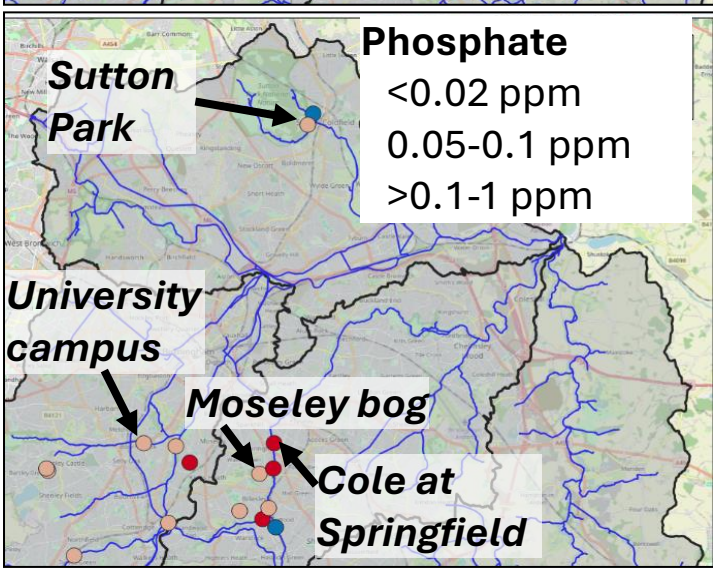
birminghamriverchampions@gmail.com

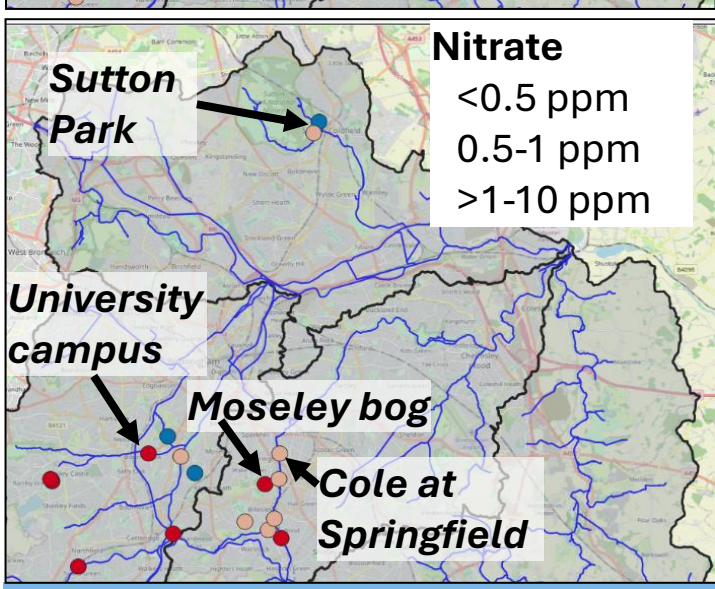
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Water chemistry results

The maps (right) show a mixed picture for different pollutants – please refer to the water chemistry information sheet for further context. Sutton Park streams tended to have the lowest concentrations across the board, while the Bourn Brook (university campus), Coldbath Brook (Moseley Bog) and the Cole at Springfield have experienced pretty high concentrations of various pollutants. Other sites had more of a mixed bag, and your ongoing monitoring will be crucial to understanding how these pollutants change over time and 'pinchpoints' that we can highlight to project partners to help drive action. Interactive maps will be published on our online app soon, as is already done for Urban Riverfly.







Midlands Today

On Wednesday, a few of us headed out to Moseley Bog and met with David Gregory Kumar to talk about the project. It will be aired early next week so stay tuned for more! A massive thanks to MosBog for organising and the volunteers who came along to support.



Upcoming events

Please note that the upcoming training in Perry Park **has been changed** to **Sunday 4th May.** And if you are able to sample **between 25th-28th this month** it will help contribute to various initiatives – see the separate flyer for more info.

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